

1 Scope

- 1.1 This policy outlines the responsibilities of Aster Group, and our customers in our approach to dealing with infestations and pests within Aster Group homes and communal areas.
- 1.2 The policy aims to protect the health and wellbeing of customers and colleagues, prevent infestations, and to facilitate efficient and effective eradication methods.
- 1.3 Aster is responsible for pests in internal communal areas, structural defects enabling pest access, and infestations spreading between properties.
- 1.4 Customers are responsible for pests within their homes unless caused by structural defects or communal issues. Local Authority handles statutory nuisances and enforcement under relevant Acts.
- 1.5 Definitions for the purpose of this policy:

Infestation refers to the presence of a large number of pests or organisms in a particular area, typically in a way that is harmful or intrusive. Infestations are typically bedbugs, fleas, and cockroaches.

Pests can include insects, rodents, pigeons, moths, or any other insect that pose a threat to human health, property, or the environment (this list is not exhaustive).

Pest control means treating pests and may include blocking their entry to properties in line with the requirement of the Human Habitation Act.

2 Policy Statement

- 2.1 Our responsibilities are to treat and eradicate infestations and pests:
 - In communal parts of our properties, such as lobbies, hallways, staircases, and bin stores.
 - In the structure of blocks of flats, such as drains, roof spaces, and car parks.
 - When the fault is with the fabric, design, or disrepair of a general needs home.
- 2.2 Customers are responsible for infestations or pests that are within their homes unless the above applies. This is in line with their tenancy agreement. When establishing responsibility, the tenancy agreement will always be referenced.
- 2.3 All customers should report an infestation or pests as soon as they become aware of this. This can be done by contacting the contact centre or informing a scheme colleague. Customers will be asked a number of triage questions before deciding on an agreed course of action.
- 2.4 When infestations or pests are reported to us, we will assess the risk by asking the customer relevant questions to ascertain the support needed.

- 2.5 We will investigate all reports of infestations and pests within our Homes for Older People (HFOP), Supported and Independent Living Schemes, Extra Care/ Sheltered Schemes, and communal areas in general needs flats.
- 2.6 Care Homes directly operated and managed by Enham and CCHT within Aster Group, are responsible for investigating, treating and eradicating all pests and infestations within all areas of the building inclusive of the curtilage.
- 2.7 Where care homes are operated by other providers as part of the 'Managed by Others' stock, treatment regimens will be carried out in line with the Management Agreement.
- 2.8 We may send an officer to assess and inspect the home for any defects after the initial triage questions. Where pests fall under our responsibility, we will carry out repairs and contract a pest controller to eradicate any pests in line with our Repairs and Maintenance Policy.
- 2.9 We may engage a professional pest control service to treat and eradicate infestations. Any treatments will be conducted in accordance with best practices or contractual terms, ensuring the safety of customers and minimising disruption. This intervention will be considered on a case-by-case basis.
- 2.10 If the responsibility for the infestation or pest does not fall with Aster, we will provide advice and signpost the customer to their local authority, or relevant pest control organisation.
- 2.11 When assessing pest and infestations, we will take into account the risks to people, environment, and property. There may be extenuating circumstances where we support customers with infestations or pests in homes when it falls outside of our responsibility. These cases will be determined by the assessing officer and the Neighbourhood teams on a case-by-case basis.
- 2.12 We will seek professional advice where appropriate. For example, for endangered or protected species, such as bats or bees, we may enlist a specialist who can control without eradication.
- 2.13 We will carefully consider the impact on the immediate community when considering what interventions may be necessary to eradicate any infestation or pests.
- 2.14 We will take reasonable steps to ensure empty homes are free from infestations and pests in line with our Lettable Standard. This will include a visual inspection of the property, including the structure, loft, and garden. Preventative or remedial works will be conducted on a case-by-case basis determined by the outcome of the inspection.
- 2.15 We advise customers in prevention of infestations or pests. We recommend regular vacuuming, washing bedding at high temperatures, keeping homes clean and uncluttered to reduce the risk.
- 2.16 It is important for the success of the infestation or pest management programme that customers co-operate with us, and any pest control professionals during inspection, treatment and follow up processes. This includes allowing access into their home, following instructions provided and disposing of infested items, as necessary. If a customer does not allow us access to their property, we will follow our Access Procedure.
- 2.17 We are not responsible for home furnishings, including floor coverings, which are damaged by, or need to be disposed of, because of pests or infestation. We recommend that customers take out a home contents insurance policy with appropriate cover.

- 2.18 We will inform colleagues, organisations, and contractors where appropriate, in particular those who may have to enter any building with an infestation, as part of their duties.
- 2.19 Customer confidentiality will be maintained regarding individual cases of infestation. Customers privacy will be respected, and personal information will only be shared with relevant personnel directly involved in the eradication process.
- 2.20 We will engage with the Local Authority Environmental Health team where we have 5 cases or 10% of flats in a block (whichever number is greater) or where for blocks of less than 5 units all flats are affected with pests or infestations.
- 2.21 Where infestation treatment is ongoing, it may be necessary to close communal areas and facilities. We will let customers know if this is the case.
- 2.22 It may be necessary to move customers whilst treatment is in process, we will let customers know if this is the case and support them in line with our Temporary Rehousing (Decant) Policy.
- 2.23 In cases where infestations are caused by customer negligence, advice from us and pest control professionals has not been followed, or for customers knowingly allowing their home to become infested on multiple occasions, we reserve the right to recharge for treatments in line with our Recharge Policy. Before we do this, we will always try to engage and work with the customer to manage the problem which includes liaising with the Local Authority Environmental Health team where appropriate.
- 2.24 We may apply a service charge for the eradication of infestations to customers who live in general needs communal flats, HFOP, Independent Living and Extra Care.
- 2.25 We will ensure everyone is treated fairly and honestly throughout, and following the complaints process, without discrimination, in line with Aster's Diversity and Inclusion Policy and Aster's Vulnerability Policy.
- 2.26 Complaints will be managed in line with our Complaints Policy.

3 Monitoring and Review

- 3.1 Policy overview sessions will be delivered to relevant teams following implementation of this policy to ensure the content and responsibilities are understood.
- 3.2 We will regularly monitor customer feedback, including complaint learnings, and the performance of pest control contracts.
- 3.3 We will review incident and financial reports to ensure value for money.
- 3.4 The effectiveness of this policy will be continuously monitored, and the embedding of the policy scrutinised after 12 months by the *Operational Leadership Team*
- 3.5 This policy will be reviewed every 3 years unless business need, regulation or legislation prompts an early review.

4 Related Policies and Procedures

This Policy, in conjunction with associated documents outlined below, sets out Aster Group's approach to meeting the requirements outlined by the RSH Tenancy Standard 2024. RSH

Neighbourhood & Community Standard 2025, Safety & Quality Standard 2025 and Transparency, Influence and Accountability Standard 2025.

Documents available to Aster Group colleagues and in the public domain

- 4.1 ASB Policy
- 4.2 Complaints Policy
- 4.3 Diversity and Inclusion Policy
- 4.4 Lettable Standard
- 4.5 Lettings Policy
- 4.6 Neighbourhood Management Policy
- 4.7 Pets Policy
- 4.8 Recharge Policy
- 4.9 Repairs and Maintenance Policy
- 4.10 Safeguarding Adults at Risk Policy
- 4.11 Safeguarding Children Policy
- 4.12 Service Charge Policy
- 4.13 Tenancy Policy
- 4.14 Vulnerability Policy
- 4.15 Customer Voice Policy
- 4.16 Domestic Abuse Policy
- 4.17 Lifts & Lifting Equipment Policy
- 4.18 Repairs and Maintenance Policy

Documents available to Aster Group colleagues only

- 4.19 Access Procedure
- 4.20 Communal Mechanical and Electrical Procedure
- 4.21 Compulsive Hoarding Procedure
- 4.22 Domestic Abuse Guidance
- 4.23 Electrical Safety Procedure
- 4.24 MAPPA & High-Risk Assessment Guidance
- 4.25 Neighbourhood Inspections Procedure
- 4.26 Neighbourhood Inspection Repairs Reporting Procedure
- 4.27 Neighbourhood Nuisance Procedure
- 4.28 Pets Procedure
- 4.29 Responsive Repairs Procedure
- 4.30 Temporary Rehousing (Decant) Procedure
- 4.31 ASB Procedure

5 Governance			
Effective From:	13/03/2026	Expires:	12/03/2029
Policy Owner:	Director of Repairs and Maintenance		
Policy Author:	Policy Officer		
Approved by:	<i>Operational Leadership Team</i>		
Scheme of Delegation Reference:	R055.15	Version Number:	V2.00

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